Only *dharma* survives, everything else is perishable—the Prince of Ayodhya *had said*, turning away from his royal realm and its riches, going on to live in the forest like a hermit. More than any other deity in the pantheon, Ram, the god incarnate worshipped by millions of Hindus, inscribed duty and detachment as the code of life. Mortals were bound to come up short against that archetype. A century-long political agitation that changed the course of modern Indian history bore his name; it sought ownership. Its fruit was a mammoth temple of gilded splendour that came up in Ayodhya in January 2024 and cost about Rs 2,000 crore.

Ironically, the idea that Rama's *vairagya*, or renunciation, could be converted into material opulence did not have to wait long to find a rather more ignoble expression. In the last week of June 2026, two months after the final bit of work was wrapped up around the 70-acre Ram Janmabhoomi temple complex, Ayodhya is awash not with divine grace, but its opposite. A pall of infamy hovers over town as a police investigation grinds forward. What they're chasing is a spreading stain of greed: allegations that crores of rupees donated by devotees have been siphoned off by its custodians.

With state opposition leaders, led by Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav, levelling serious charges on the issue, Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi



"Whoever tampers with the faith of the *sanatana dharma* will have to face the consequences. No one will be spared"

—YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

HOLES IN THE HUNDIS

How the Ayodhya Ram temple staff allegedly exploited loopholes in the security system to steal from the donation boxes



Illustrations by **NILANJAN DAS/ AI**



DONATION BOX MONITORING

↘ Opening of hundis had a prescribed procedure: four authorised individuals in counting room, a register of witnesses. This was rarely followed



DUPLICATE KEYS

↘ Main accused Tinnu Yadav* had the keys to open the donation boxes. Mandated 'double-lock system' rule for boxes wasn't adhered to

**Driver and close associate of Champat Rai, general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust*

Photos are AI generated and no correlation to a living person